

The actual tombs in the subterranean chamber. Picture by William Donelson

The interiors show their great debt to Muslim and Persian art through their elaborate use of decorative tiles and mosaics. In fact, the entire interior is completely covered in elaborate geometric and floral patterns, many of them in stunning colors that contrast with the relative simplicity of the white marble exterior. In addition to these patterns, Muslim artists have always considered calligraphy to be one of their greatest art forms, and it was used extensively in the structure. This is because the traditional Sunni interpretation of the Qur'an has forbidden the depiction of humans or animals to prevent them becoming the objects of worship. This, along with their deep veneration for the Qur'an as the word of God, has meant that they have turned their artistic energies to the depiction of beauty through words themselves. This love of the written word has long been fused with Muslim architecture as well, and the Taj has a number of beautiful pieces of calligraphic inscription drawn entirely from the Qur'an.[33]